

The Rising Cost of Infant Care: A State-by-State Analysis

Georgette Joseph

Summary of Analysis

Findings

The analysis of the National Database of Childcare Prices (2008–2018) reveals several consistent trends in the cost of infant childcare across the United States. First, center-based infant care is consistently more expensive than home-based care across all states and years. The national trend shows that both types of care have increased steadily over time, with center-based care maintaining a persistent premium price.

Second, childcare costs increased significantly over the decade examined. Between 2008 and 2018, both home-based and center-based infant care costs increased by more than 20 percent nationally. This upward trend indicates growing affordability challenges for families who rely on childcare in order to participate in the workforce.

Third, geographic disparities are substantial. State-level comparisons show that families in certain states, including Hawaii, California, Washington, and Massachusetts, face significantly higher weekly childcare costs than families in other parts of the country. These regional differences highlight the influence of location on childcare affordability.

Finally, the analysis reveals a notable cost gap between care models. In many states, center-based infant care costs more than \$100 per week above home-based care. This difference reflects pricing differences between childcare models and contributes to the financial burden faced by many families.

Together, these findings demonstrate that infant childcare affordability is a growing and uneven financial challenge across the United States.

Assumptions

Several assumptions guided this analysis:

The dataset accurately reflects childcare prices reported across states and years.

The variables representing home-based and center-based infant care correspond to the definitions provided in the dataset documentation.

Weekly cost averages reasonably represent overall affordability trends.

Economic factors such as inflation affect childcare prices across states in generally similar ways, although some regional variation may exist.

Items That Still Need Clarification

Although the analysis shows clear patterns, several questions remain that could be explored in future research:

How do urban and rural differences influence childcare costs within states?

How do childcare prices compare to median household income levels?

What role do government subsidies and childcare policies play in cost differences across states?

How do childcare workforce wages affect pricing trends?

Further analysis incorporating income data and regional policy differences could provide deeper insight into childcare affordability.

Direction of Story / Message

The central message of this project is that infant childcare costs in the United States are rising steadily and vary significantly depending on care type and location. These differences create uneven financial pressure for families and highlight broader affordability challenges in the childcare system.

The narrative progresses in three stages. First, national trend analysis confirms that childcare costs have increased consistently over time. Second, a comparison between home-based and center-based care reveals a persistent structural cost difference, with center-based care remaining more expensive. Finally, state-level comparisons demonstrate that geographic location significantly influences affordability.

By connecting national trends, care type comparisons, and state level differences, the analysis highlights how childcare affordability is shaped not only by household budgets but also by broader economic and policy factors.

Target Audience

The primary audience for this analysis include policymakers, childcare advocacy organizations, researchers, journalists, and parents seeking awareness of childcare cost trends. Different communication mediums were selected to effectively present the findings to both analytical and general audiences.

Mediums Included and Why

Three mediums were used to communicate the findings of this project.

Power BI Dashboard: The interactive dashboard allows users to explore childcare costs by state and year through filters and visual comparisons. This format supports deeper exploration of patterns and is particularly useful for policymakers and analysts.

Infographic: The infographic presents the most important insights in a concise and visually engaging format. It highlights key trends and affordability concerns for families and is designed for a broader public audience.

Presentation Deck: The presentation provides a structured narrative that explains the analysis step by step. It introduces the problem, presents key findings, and explains the implications for families and policymakers.

Design Decisions

The design of this project was guided by clarity, consistency, and accessibility. Because the topic focuses on childcare affordability, visuals were designed to be professional yet approachable for non-technical audiences.

A consistent color palette was used across all mediums to distinguish between home-based and center-based care while maintaining visual cohesion. Line charts were used to illustrate trends over time, while bar charts were used to compare costs across states and highlight differences between care types.

Charts were positioned prominently with concise explanatory text to ensure viewers can quickly identify key insights without being overwhelmed by excessive detail.

Ethical Considerations

The dataset used in this analysis was filtered to focus on infant care costs between 2008 and 2018. No values were altered, and averages were calculated only to summarize trends across states and years.

The data originates from the National Database of Childcare Prices and publicly available sources, including the U.S. Department of Labor and Child Care Aware of America. Because the dataset contains no personal identifiable information, there are no privacy concerns.

One potential risk of misinterpretation is viewing cost increases without considering factors such as inflation or regional income differences. To mitigate this risk, visualizations clearly label time frames and cost units.

Lessons Learned

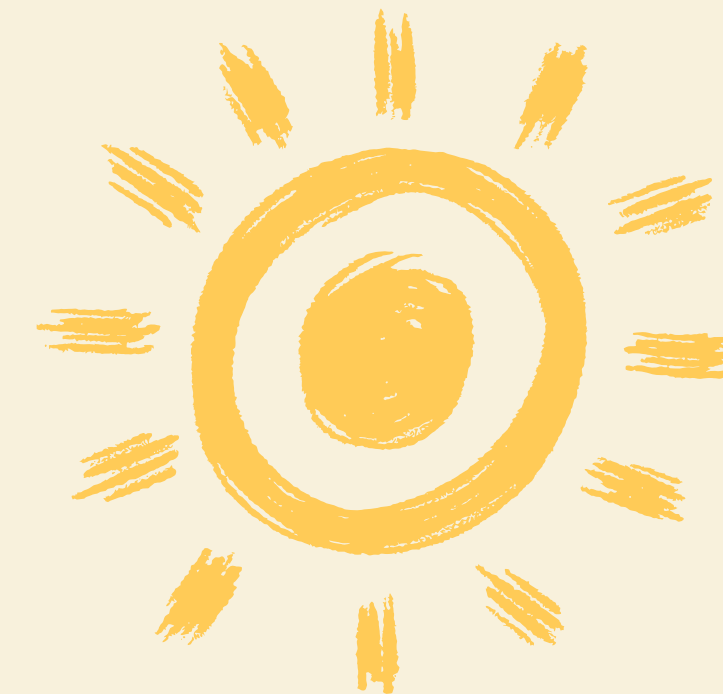
If I conduct this analysis again, additional comparisons between childcare costs and household income levels would provide a clearer understanding of affordability. Incorporating regional policy data or urban–rural comparisons could also strengthen the analysis.

The most rewarding aspect of this project was transforming raw data into visual insights that highlight real-world challenges faced by families. Connecting statistical patterns with everyday financial realities made the analysis both meaningful and relevant.

Conclusion

The findings of this project show that infant childcare costs have risen steadily across the United States over the past decade. Center-based care remains consistently more expensive than home-based care, and substantial geographic disparities exist between states.

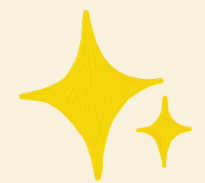
By presenting these findings through multiple visual mediums, including a dashboard, infographic, and presentation, this project communicates both the analytical trends and the broader implications for families and policymakers. As childcare costs continue to increase, data-driven insights such as these can support more informed discussions about childcare accessibility, workforce participation, and economic stability for families.



The Rising Cost of Infant Care: A State-by-State Analysis

By: Georgette Joseph





Why Infant Care Costs Matter for Families

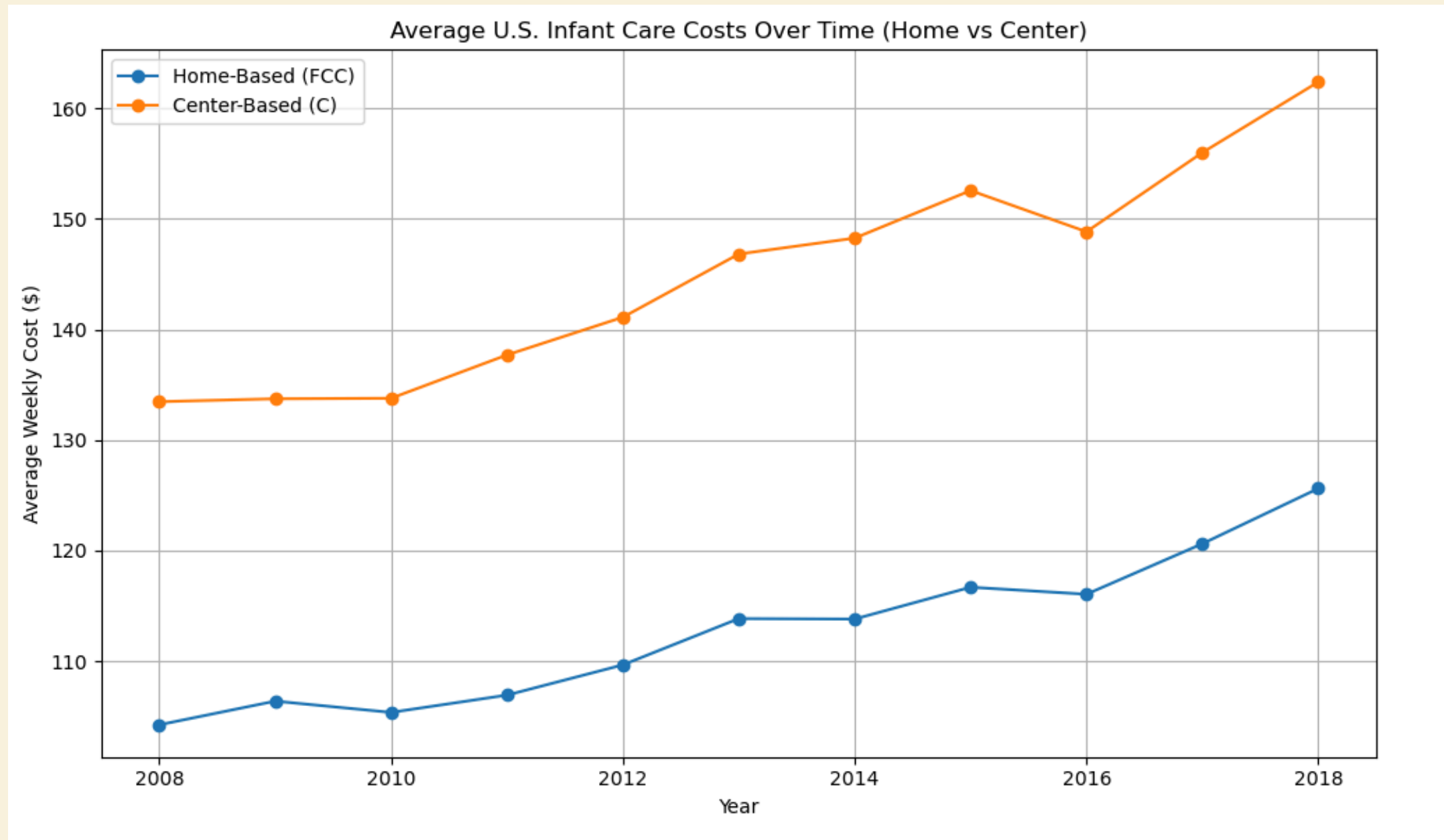
- Infant care is one of the largest ongoing expenses for families with young children
- Costs vary widely across the United States, depending on where families live
- Rising childcare costs place increasing financial pressure on working families



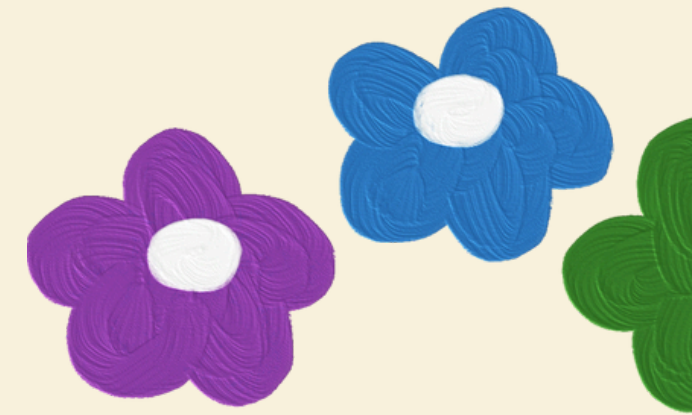


National Infant Care Cost Trends (2008-2018)

- Infant childcare costs increased steadily between 2008 and 2018
- Center-based care remained consistently more expensive than home-based care
- Rising costs reflect growing affordability challenges for working families

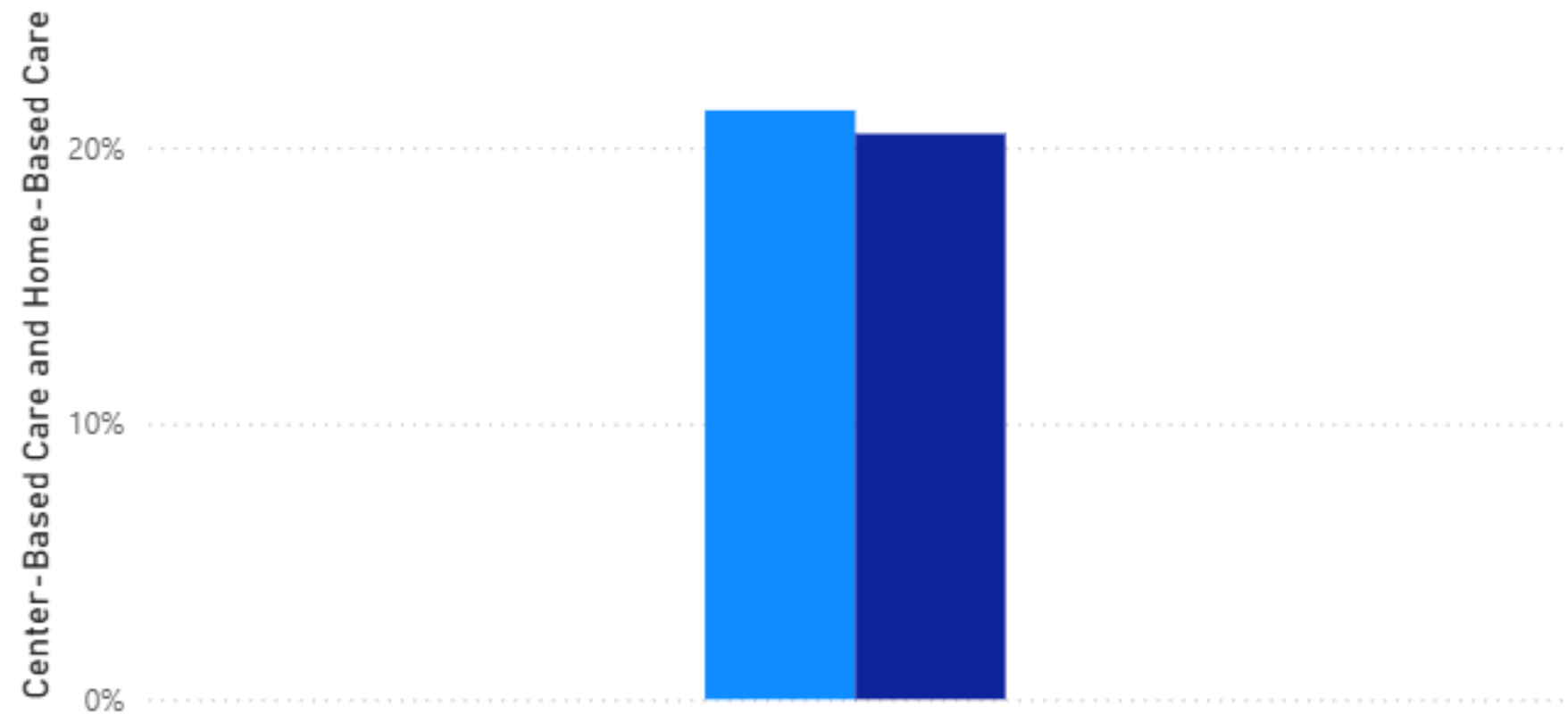


Growth in Infant Care Costs (2008–2018)



Infant Care Cost Growth (2008–2018)

● Center-Based Care ● Home-Based Care

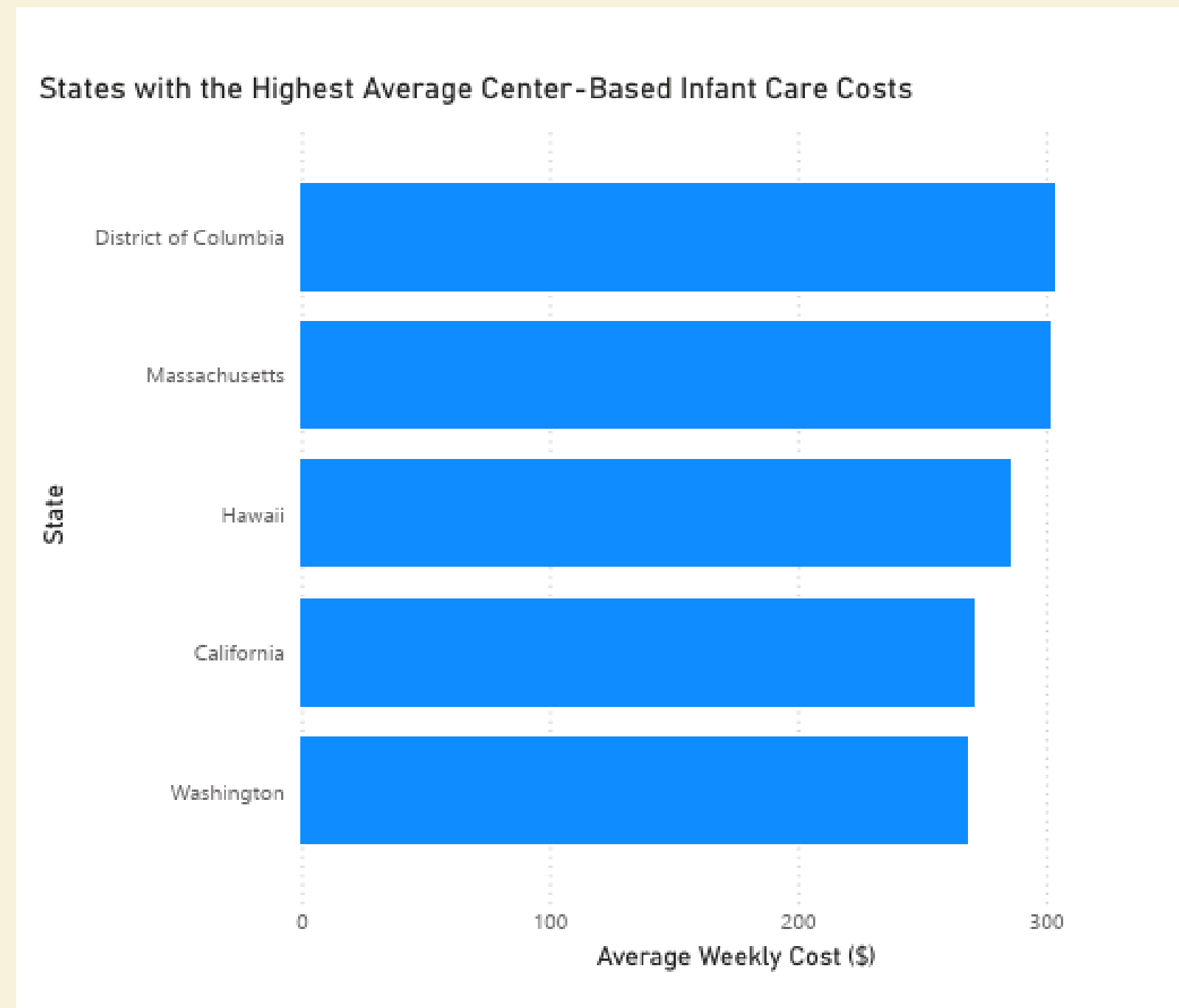


- Infant care costs increased by more than 20% over the decade
- Center-based care experienced slightly faster growth than home-based care
- These increases contribute to rising financial pressure for families



States with the Highest Infant Care Costs [Center-Based]

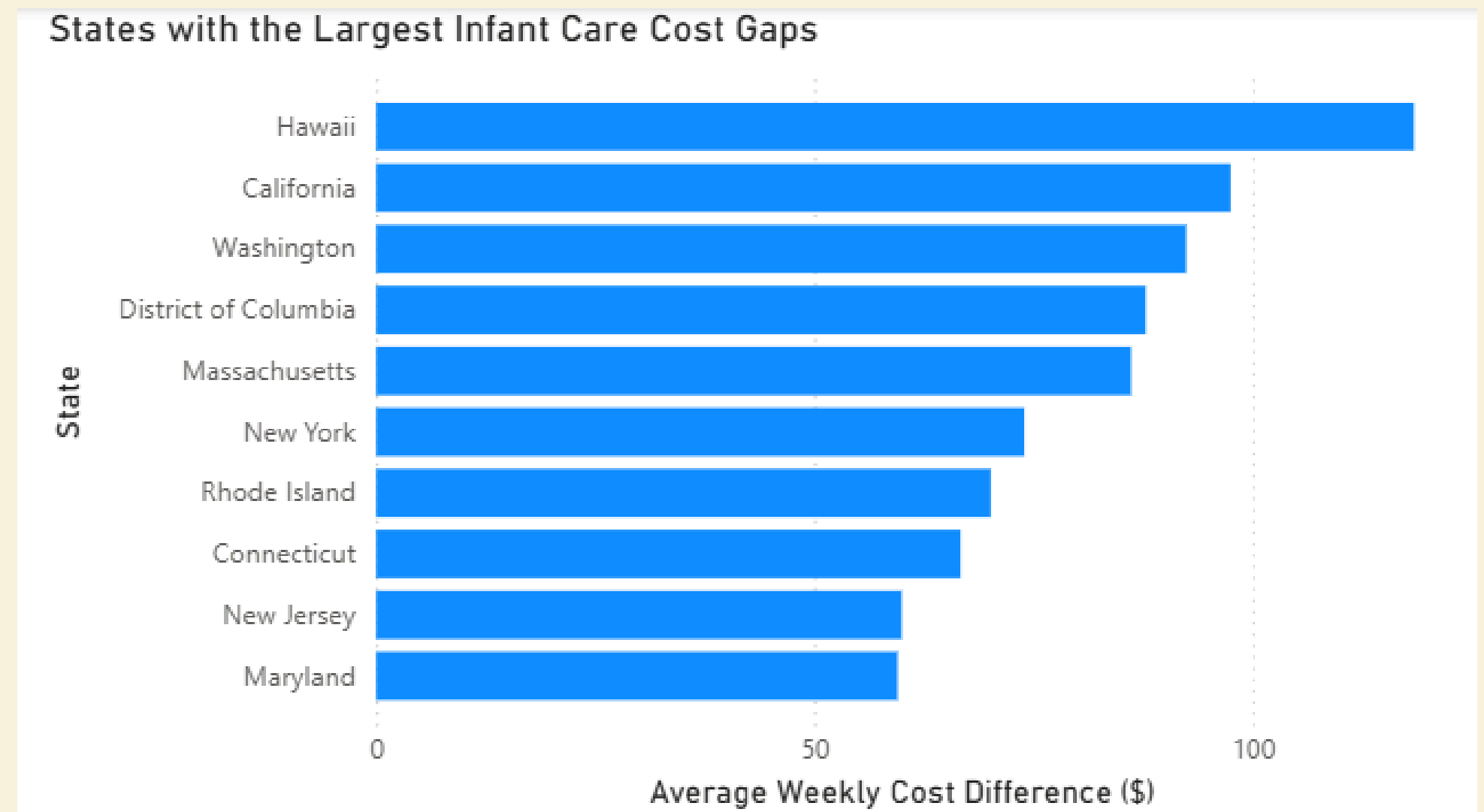
- Infant care costs vary significantly across states
- Some states consistently experience much higher weekly costs
- Geographic location plays a major role in childcare affordability





States with the Largest Infant Care Cost Gaps

- **Center-based infant care costs significantly more than home-based care**
- **In some states, the difference exceeds \$100 per week**
- **This gap highlights structural cost differences between care models**





Key Takeaways for Families and Policymakers

- Center-based infant care costs are consistently higher than home-based care
- Infant care costs continue to rise over time
- Families in certain states face substantially higher financial burdens than others





Data Sources

- National Database of Childcare Prices (2008–2018)
- U.S. Department of Labor / Child Care Aware of America
- Analysis and visualizations created by Georgette Joseph

The Rising Cost of Infant Care: A State-by-State Analysis (Draft Dashboard)

By: Georgette Joseph

State

All

Year

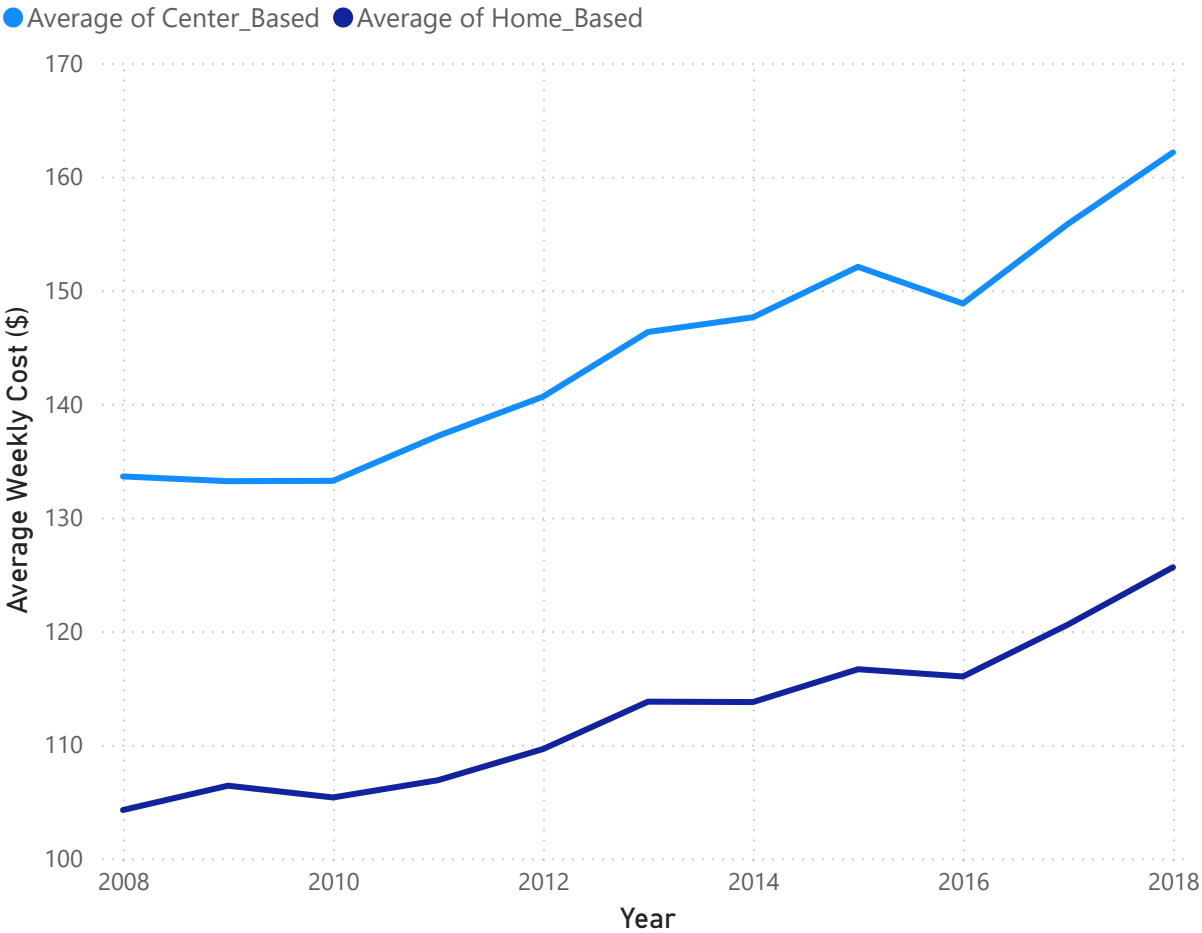
2008

2018

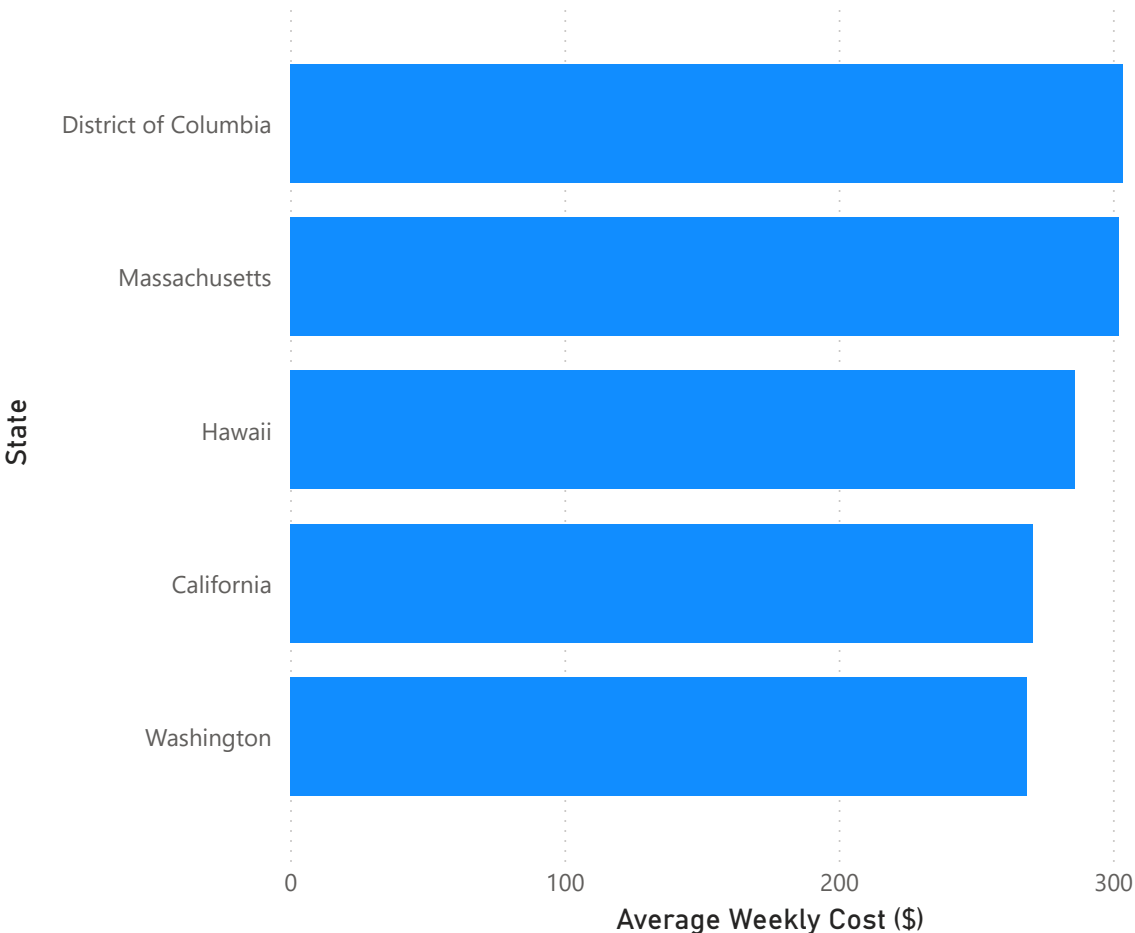
Key takeaways

- Center-based infant care is consistently more expensive than home-based care
- Costs rise over time, showing increasing affordability pressure
- Some states face much higher average costs than others

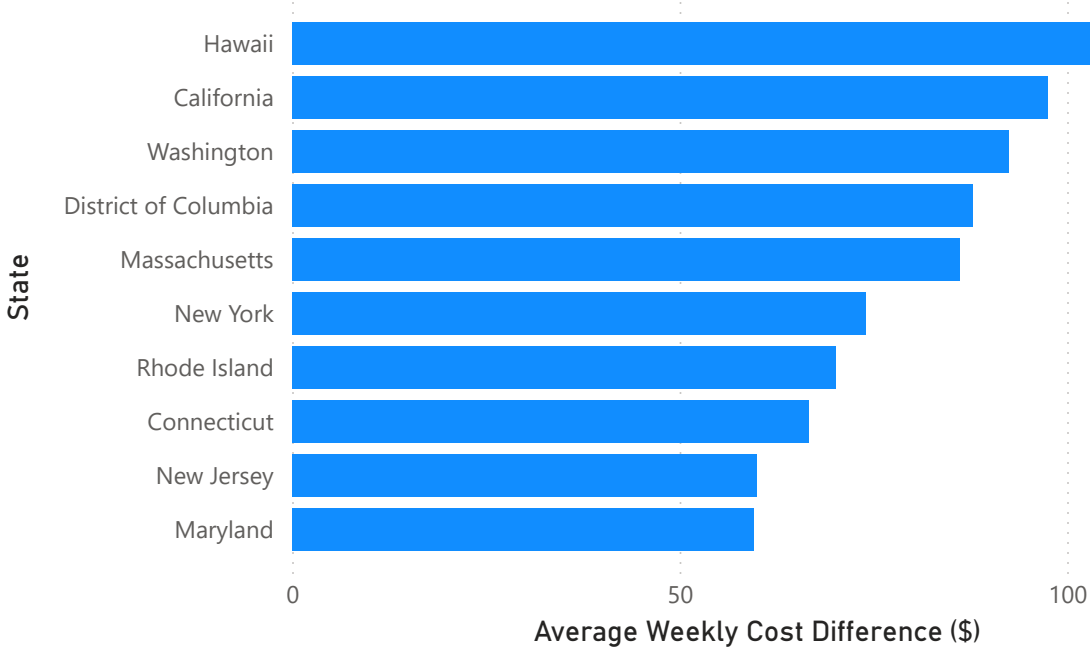
Average U.S. Infant Care Costs Over Time (Home vs Center)



States with the Highest Average Center-Based Infant Care Costs



States with the Largest Infant Care Cost Gaps



Infant Care Cost Growth (2008–2018)

